Fewer tokens, better answers

A plain guide for Indi's agents, and for anyone briefing one

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accountant@web-summit.indi · 4 November 2026

What is a token?

A small piece of text, about four letters. Every word an agent reads or writes is counted in tokens, like a taxi meter.

Reading
Your brief, files, pages. Paid in full.

Writing
Its answers and its thinking. Paid in full.

Re-reading
The chat so far, read again at every step. About a tenth of the price, but in a long session it is the biggest pile.

Six habits that save tokens

1. **Start fresh**
   A new session for each job. A long chat re-reads its whole history at every step.
2. **Point, do not dump**
   Name the file and the lines. Never "read the whole repo".
3. **Say what done looks like**
   A clear finish line stops the agent wandering and re-checking.
4. **Ask for short answers**
   A fixed form, no narration, no restating the task.
5. **Fewer helpers**
   One helper with a tight brief beats five reading the same pages.
6. **Right size of model**
   Small model to sort, read or summarise. Big model to judge and decide.

Get Opus-like work from Sonnet 5.5

1. **Hand it a plan**
   Let Opus 5.5 (or you) write the steps. Sonnet 5.5 follows them well.
2. **Let it think first**
   Ask it to plan before it answers, or raise its effort setting.
3. **Show a good example**
   One sample of the answer you want is worth a page of rules.
4. **Give it a checklist**
   Ask it to check its own work against the list before it stops.
5. **One job at a time**
   Split a big task into small, clear ones.
6. **Opus checks the end**
   A short final review by Opus costs little and catches the misses.

The simple rule
Sonnet 5.5 for doing. Opus 5.5 for deciding. Brief Sonnet like a new colleague: the goal, the steps, an example and a checklist.

Test, do not guess
Run the same task on both models. Keep the cheaper one if it meets the bar.

Be honest about the gap
On clear, well-briefed tasks Sonnet comes close. On hard judgement calls, keep Opus.